

The Four Words

Truth, Proof, Progress, Restraint. The book puts four words underneath everything StartPad does. They work as well underneath a company as underneath a brand.



“Four words underneath everything. Truth. Proof. Progress. Restraint.”

StartPad Brand Presentation, GrowthLabs Group, 2026 · Chapter 02 · Brand DNA

Values that can be failed are worth having.

Most stated company values cannot be failed. Integrity, excellence, innovation — nobody has ever been caught breaching them, because there is no act that would count. The four below are different: each one forbids something specific and common, which is what makes them usable.

01

Truth

Names the requirement before the encouragement. Bad news arrives unsoftened.

THE FOUNDER TEST

Did you state the gap before you stated the plan?

02

Proof

Proves rather than claims. Every number sourced, every status earned.

THE FOUNDER TEST

Could a stranger check your last claim without asking you?

03

Progress

Makes progress visible from outside. Movement is the thing the system displays.

THE FOUNDER TEST

Can somebody tell you moved this month without being told?

04

Restraint

Never takes credit for the launch. The founder progressed; the platform stayed.

THE FOUNDER TEST

Whose name is on the outcome when it goes well?

The book gives the first line of each. The founder test is this report's addition — a value with no test is a poster.

Four words, each with something it forbids. Read the tests rather than the words: the test is the part that can be failed on a Tuesday.

Bad news arrives unsoftened.

The operational form of this is narrow and hard: when something has gone wrong, the first sentence says so. Not the third sentence, after two of context. Founders invert this almost universally, and the inversion is expensive because the reader learns to wait for the bad news rather than to read the good.

SAY	NEVER SAY
We missed the target. Here is why and here is the plan.	Lots of exciting progress this month!
Two of the four are not done.	Great momentum across the board.
The pilot failed. We are stopping it.	We're iterating on the pilot.
I was wrong about the customer.	We've learned so much.

Why this one pays

A founder who leads with bad news is believed when they lead with good news. That is the entire mechanism, and it is the cheapest credibility available to somebody with no track record.

02 · Proof

Every number sourced, every status earned.

The discipline here is a habit rather than a principle: a number never travels without its source and its denominator. Once that is automatic, an investor update and an application stop being writing tasks and become assembly tasks, because the sourcing already happened when the number was first written down.

SOURCED	UNSOURCED
11 of 34 paid a deposit — payment log, April	Roughly a third converted
6 of 10 returned unprompted — delivery log, weeks 4 to 6	Most users come back
Median 4 hours a week — as stated in 17 interviews	It saves people a lot of time

The right column is what the left column decays into in about a fortnight, if the source is not written down at the moment the number is.

Visible from outside, without being announced.

The book's formulation is precise: *makes progress visible from outside*. Not reports progress — makes it visible. The difference is who has to do the work. A founder whose progress requires a monthly email to be perceived has built something opaque; one whose repository, changelog or public list moves on its own has not.

VISIBLE FROM OUTSIDE

Somebody noticed before you told them

The only rung that is genuinely visible from outside.

A public artefact that moves on its own

A changelog, a list, a shipped thing with a date on it.

A monthly update that people read

Visible, but you are carrying it.

A monthly update nobody reads

The most common, and functionally invisible.

Progress you would have to be asked about

Real work. Nobody knows.

INVISIBLE

Ranked by who does the work of noticing. Most founders sit on the fourth rung and conclude that the market is not paying attention.

04 · Restraint

The founder progressed; the platform stayed.

This is the strangest of the four to find in a brand book, because it instructs the brand not to claim its own results. For a founder the equivalent is about a team: when it goes well, the person who did it is named, and when it goes badly, you are. It costs nothing and it is almost never done, which is why it is noticed.

It also has a commercial form. Restraint is what stops a founder claiming their customer's outcome as their own — the difference between “we grew their revenue 40%” and “they grew 40%; we handled the logistics”. The second is more credible and, in a small market where the customer will be asked, considerably safer.

Four questions, once a month.

Worksheet · The four tests

MONTHLY, TEN MINUTES

Answer from the month that just ended, not the one you intend to have.

Truth — the worst thing that happened, and who I told first

If nobody was told, that is the answer to the test.

Proof — a claim I made this month, and its source

Progress — what somebody outside could see moved, unprompted

Restraint — a result I took credit for that somebody else produced

The honest answer is rarely “none”.

Do not adopt all four at once

Pick the one you failed most clearly this month and run it for a quarter. Four new disciplines starting on the same Monday is how a values exercise becomes a document nobody opens again.

The book lists five behaviours alongside these four words, one of which — speaking the way your audience speaks, composed rather than translated — is a communications discipline rather than an operating one, and is the subject of **Report 07**.



StartPad tells you the truth about whether you are ready, gets you ready, and gives you the proof.

What it is

A founder-readiness platform for Egypt and the wider MENA region. It takes a young person who has an idea and no company, moves them through fifteen structured missions, and turns them into someone the ecosystem will take seriously — then issues verifiable proof of that.

It is not a course platform, not an education brand and not a youth club. Nothing here is graded. Every mission ends in an artefact you own.

Three moves, always in this order

TRUTH Where you actually stand

Measured against what programmes actually ask for, stated plainly, before any encouragement.

READINESS Fifteen structured missions

They close the specific gaps the assessment found, in the order that matters. A route, not a curriculum.

PROOF A verifiable credential

The ecosystem can check it without asking you. You apply with a file, not a hope.

On your idea

StartPad earns when a founder gets into somewhere — an accelerator, a programme, a room. Taking a founder's idea would end that. Work submitted to a mission is sealed and timestamped to the person who submitted it, and the seal is the product.

Nothing in this document asks you to give anything up to use it. It is yours to fill in, print, and hand to whoever needs to see it.

startpad.me

Start with the readiness assessment. It is free and it takes about twenty minutes.